

NOTE TAKING GUIDE FOR INTERPRETERS



TABLE OF CONTENTS

The nuts and bolts of note taking	p. 2
Tips for note taking	p.3
- Openness and willingness	p.3
- Abbreviations (Definition and examples)	p.4-7
- Symbols (Definition and examples)	p.8-9
- Using arrows	p.10-11
- Organizing notes	p.12-13
Practice time	p.14-15



THE NUTS AND BOLTS OF NOTE TAKING

Note taking, like any other skill, requires practice and patience. The development of a good note taking technique will not happen overnight. It is necessary to tailor this system to our own needs and dedicate time to practice it!



It is important to acknowledge that consolidating a good note taking system requires time, practice, commitment and exposure. Give yourself the chance to try new strategies and methods that will help you. It might not be perfect at first, but as long as you see some improvement every day, you will be on the right track.



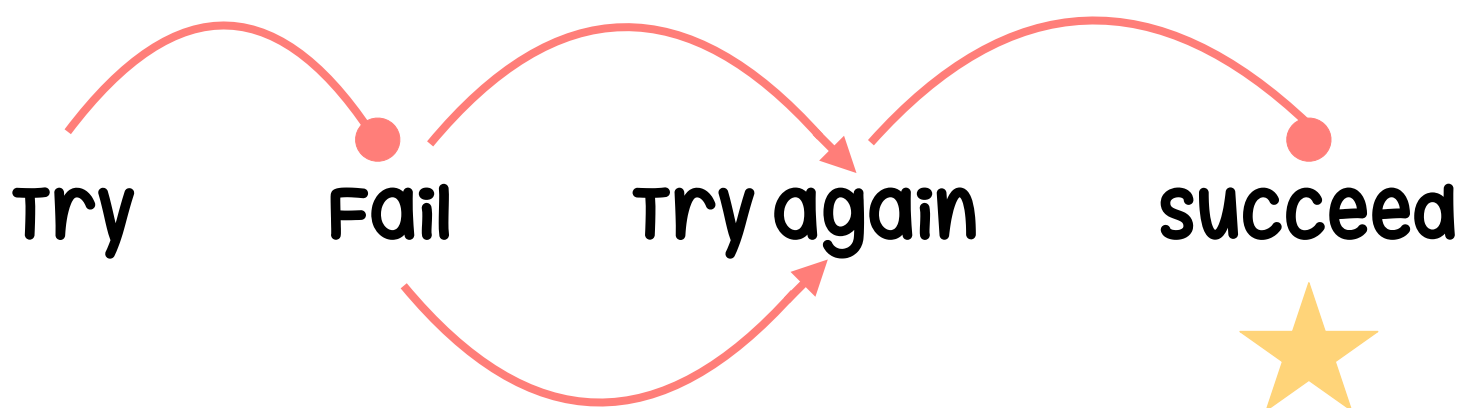


TIPS FOR NOTE TAKING

Openness and willingness: Working on developing our note-taking skill can be overwhelming and frustrating at times, but good interpreters will always find the best way out.

Notes are *very personal* and every interpreter takes notes in a very unique and particular way. **Trial and error** is part of this process until you find a methodology that suits you best. However, you must be willing and open to try.

Avoid frustration and achieve success.





ABBREVIATIONS

Abbreviating is the process of shortening words or phrases. The rule of thumb in note taking is:

If you can abbreviate, you should abbreviate.

Nevertheless, using abbreviations is not just about shortening words or phrases as much as you can, we must also make sure to understand our notes later on. Otherwise, anything written down will be useless.



Drop the vowels whenever it's possible

Week *Wk*

Claim *Clm*

Worker *Wrkr*

Adjuster *Adjstr*

Month *Mnth*

Nurse *Nrs*



Incorporate numerals and go with phonetics

Later *L8r*

Wait *w8*

Forward *4wrđ*

Too late *2L8*

Before *B4*

Today *2dy*



Play around with words that convey the same meaning but are shorter

On the other hand, However, Nevertheless *But*

Because, for this reason, since, given the fact that, etc. *As/why*

To finish, to terminate, closure, etc. *End*

Well, alright, to agree, fine, etc. *OK*

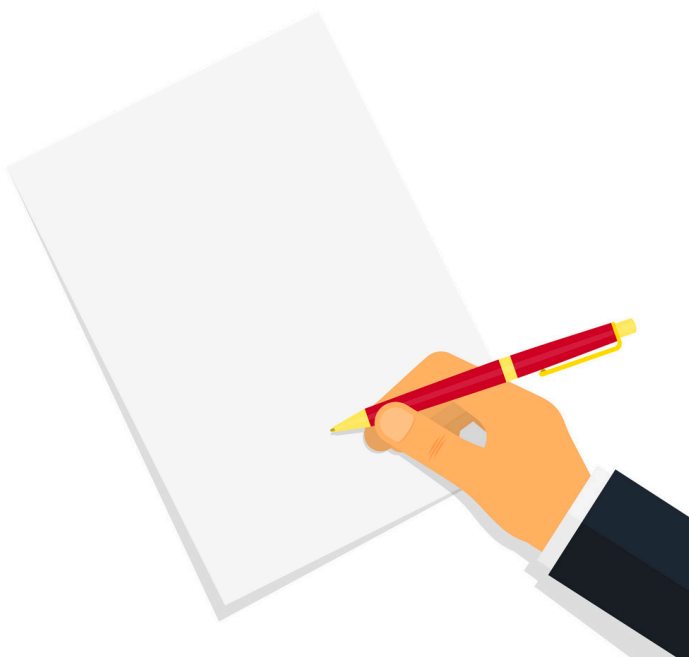
In this moment, right away, immediately *Now*





Use acronyms for some commonly used terms

Medical record number	<i>MRN</i>	Date of Birth	<i>DOB</i>
Social Security Administration	<i>SSA</i>	Out-of-pocket expense(money)	<i>OOP\$</i>
Social Security Number	<i>SSN</i>	Bank of America (proper name)	<i>BoA</i>
Primary Care Physician	<i>PCP</i>	Blue Cross and Blue Shield (Proper name)	<i>BCBS</i>
Mother -in-law	<i>MIL</i>	Father-in-law	<i>FIL</i>
Year, make and model	<i>YMM</i>	Over-the-counter	<i>OTC</i>





Negation:

There is an effective way to abbreviate negative statements by using (-), (X) or by crossing out a word or symbol.

ORG: "Sorry, I do not have money in this moment".

Sry, - \$ RN
Sry, **X**hv \$ RN
Sry, ~~hav~~ \$ RN

ORG: "She does not feel very well"

She - fl ok
She **X**fl ok
She fl ok

(OK is underlined to abbreviate the intensifier "very")

Now, it's your turn to try!

Create your own abbreviations.

There are plenty of ways to shorten particular common words and phrases but we encourage you to use your personal abbreviations to improve your notes.

You can do it!





SYMBOLS

Symbols can represent a term, phrase or even an idea. A simple drawing, trace or even a single letter can be used as a symbol.

Little by little, start incorporating simple yet effective symbols in your notes.

Practice is key in order to remember the symbols we've created and their meaning.



Common symbols

Number, amount	#	After, in the future, the next day	➡
Yesterday, past, before	⬅	Minus, less, decrease	-, ⬇
More, add, a lot, much, many	+, ⬆	Pay, money	\$



Common symbols (part 2)

Like, love, preference	♥	Money	\$
Happy, content, excited	😊	Phone, phone number	☎
Mail, letter, envelope	✉	Talk, conversation	“A”
Female, male	♀ ♂	Unfortunately, sadly, uncomfortable	☹



Re-use symbols

Money	\$	Rent	\$r	Mortgage	\$m
Bill	฿	Billing address	฿ add	Billing department	฿ dpt





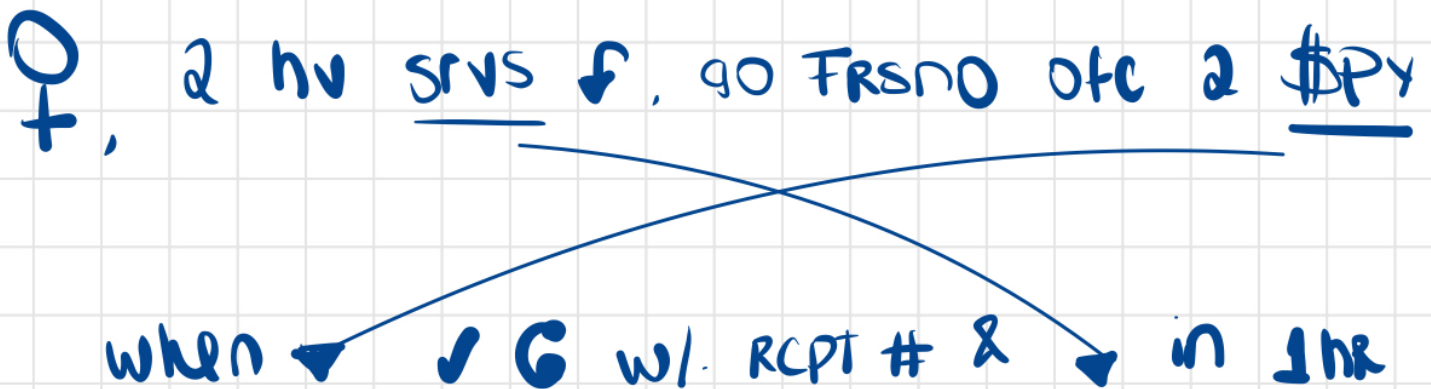
USE ARROWS

By taking notes in a vertical way you will be able to incorporate arrows to connect ideas, terms, concepts and/or phrases.

By doing this, re-writing something that was previously stated in your notes is avoided, making the best out of those precious seconds we have to render accurately.

Example 1:

“Ma’am, In order to get our services back, you need to go Fresno’s office to make the payment. Once that payment is done, you may call us with the receipt number and the service will be restored within the next hour.”

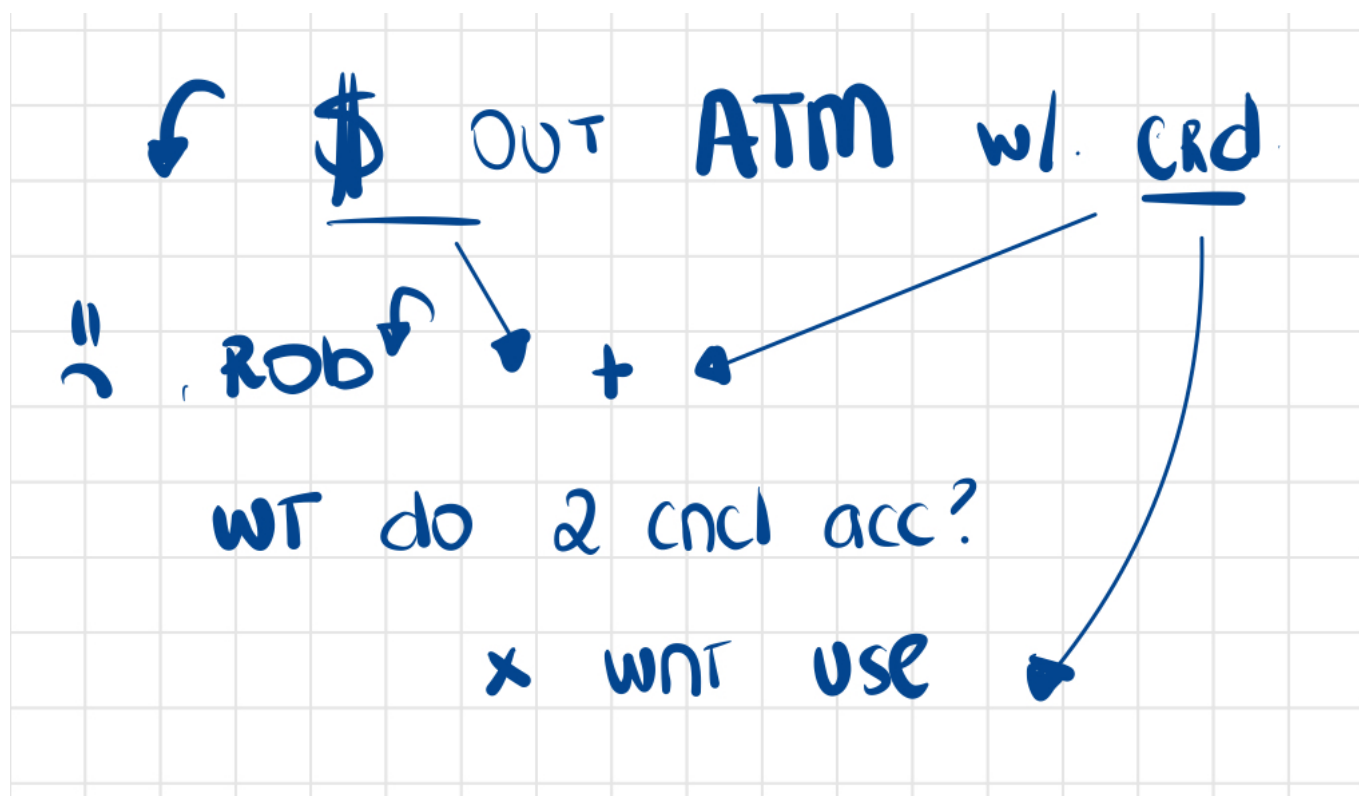


♀, 2 hv srvs ↓, go Fresno ofc 2 \$py
when ✓ G w/ RCPT # & in 1hr



Example 2:

“Anoche retiré dinero del cajero automático con mi tarjeta. Lamentablemente, me robaron el dinero y la tarjeta también. ¿Qué puedo hacer para cancelar mi cuenta? No quiero que nadie use mi tarjeta.”



ORGANIZING NOTES



Going vertically/ stacking

Vertically / stacking - Listing: It has been proved that putting ideas as a list helps our memory not to forget details.

In note-taking, listing or going vertically means taking notes from top to bottom (sometimes following a diagonal pattern) rather than going from left to right by keeping only main ideas and key words. This method represents the backbone of the note-taking system for many interpreters, since it:



Allows to group ideas logically, keeping a complete and immediate synthesis when we come to read back our notes.

Helps to create links which would be essential to the clarity of the text.

Helps to collect factual data conveniently.

Allows organizing ideas by keeping mainly key words, on a list.



Example 1:

“Good morning, thank you for calling SouthwestPro Bank, my name is James. To further assist you, may I please, have your first and last name, your date of birth, address including zip code, account number and the reason for your call?”

Idea 1	gm, thx G SWHST PRO BNK, me James
Idea 2	+ hlp, 1n & ln
Idea 3	dob
Idea 4	add + zip
Idea 5	acc #
Idea 6	RSN G?

Example 2:

“Llamo para hacerle saber qué tuve un accidente esta mañana alrededor de las 8:30am, entre la Columbus St y la 5th St. Iba saliendo del estacionamiento del centro comercial cuando un carro que iba frente al mío frenó de la nada. Yo no pude frenar a tiempo y choqué por detrás”

Idea 1	G 2 lgr knw f acc  @ 8:30
Idea 2	CImbus ST  5 st
Idea 3	OUT Mall pkng
Idea 4	whn <u>car</u> → me sudd STOP
Idea 5	- brk on T & R end 

Practice time!

Below you'll find a conversation between a Client and a LEP person. In the notes we can see some of the useful tips previously explained being put into practice. Take a look at the abbreviations and symbols used.

"Thank you for calling CVS pharmacy. I need your name, the last four digits of your social security number, date of birth and reason for the call"

Thx 6 CVS

nd:

n:

SS4:

dob:

why 6:

"Buenos días, soy Sandra Gomez. Los últimos cuatro de mi social son 3987, nací el 8 de junio del 52 y llamo porque necesito surtir mi medicamento recetado por el Dr. Sanchez."

~~Thx 6 CVS~~

~~nd:~~

gm ✓

n: Sandra gmz

SS4: 3987

dob: 8 / JUN / 52

why 6: ⬇ fill Rx by DR Sanchez

"I can see here that there is a refill order for Metformin. This is formulary medication for your insurance plan which means that you only need to pay \$5".

I ⦿ ⬇ fill order 4 Metformin

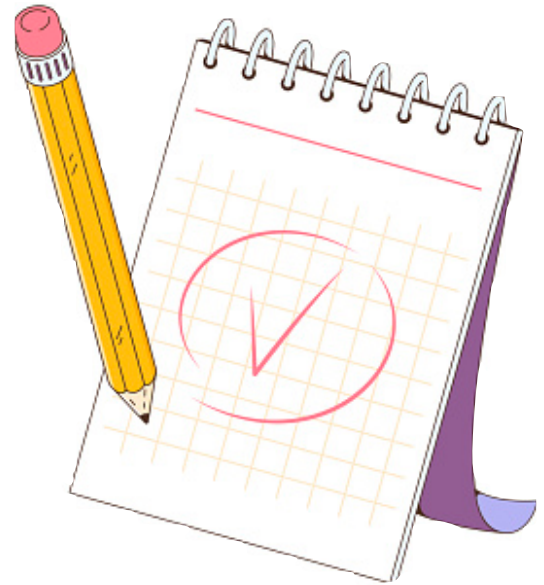
≡ med ⬇
ins plan

∴ \$p → \$5



NOW IT'S YOUR TURN!

The objective of this guide is to provide useful tips to inspire you to create an efficient note taking technique based on what works for you.



During this journey, give yourself the chance to try and experiment with different methods, strategies and tips until you find what best suits your needs.

Remember: *Note taking* and *memory retention* work together! The idea of taking notes it's to trigger your short term memory in order to render **complete** and **accurate** messages.

It is a slow but growing process in which learning is at every step of the way.

YOU
CAN
DO IT

